USC Dornsife
Dana and David Dornsife
College of Letters, Arts and Sciences
Spatial Sciences Institute

SSCI 397: Spatial Sciences Internship

Syllabus

Units: 2-4

Term Day Time: Spring 2026

Location: On or off-campus but not within the Spatial Sciences Institute

Instructor: Dr. Darren Ruddell, GISP
Office: AHF B57F
Office Hours: Mondays 1:30-2:30pm, Wednesdays 12-1pm, and by appointment via email
Contact Info: druddell@usc.edu, 213-740-0521

Library Help: Andy Rutkowski
Office: LIPA B40-A
Office Hours: By appointment via email
Contact Info: arutkows@usc.edu

IT Help: Spatial Support
Contact Info: spatial_support@usc.edu

Course Description

The purpose of a Spatial Sciences Internship is for a student to gain part- or full-time practical work experience to apply and further his or her understanding of the principles presented in his or her degree program. The internship may be located at an on- or off-campus facility, but not within the Spatial Sciences Institute. Each student is individually supervised by a faculty member.

No more than 4 units of SSCI 397 are allowed for credit towards a single degree.

During the semester, the student will remain in contact with the professor who has agreed to supervise him or her and will report regularly as agreed upon between the student and the professor.

By the end of the semester, the student will produce a report of his or her work activity, problems investigated or work product undertaken, significant results, and any follow-up projects in which the student may have engaged. If a different format is used other than a report, that format must meet the same intellectual standard as that described here. In this case, the faculty supervisor will document the definition of an alternative deliverable of intellectual merit equivalent to a report.

The student will write a letter of appreciation to the non-profit organization, private company, or public agency for the opportunity to intern.

In the course of the internship, the student must not violate the company's policies on intellectual property and/or confidentiality and must abide by all other relevant company policies.

Learning Outcomes

Upon completion of this course, the student should be able to:

- Articulate an awareness of the company's or agency's role in the relevant industry.
- Describe a scope of work and how the student delivered work product(s) in fulfillment of that scope of work.
- Demonstrate application of principles and concepts learned in the academic program to real-world contexts.
- Produce documentation as to the benefits of the internship experience.

Requirements for Enrollment

To enroll, students must be in good academic standing (cumulative and degree GPA of at least 3.00). On a case-by-case basis, students with a cumulative or major GPA below 3.00 may be permitted to take this course. The student must provide the faculty supervisor with a verifiable internship offer letter from a non-profit organization, private company, or public agency.

Prerequisite(s): None
Co-Requisite (s): None
Concurrent Enrollment: None
Recommended Preparation: None

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Class Conduct

Harassment, sexual misconduct, interpersonal violence, and stalking are not tolerated by the university. All faculty and most staff are considered Responsible Employees by the university and must forward all information they receive about these types of situations to the Title IX Coordinator. The Title IX Coordinator is responsible for assisting students with supportive accommodations, including academic accommodations, as well as investigating these incidents if the reporting student wants an investigation. The Title IX office is also responsible for coordinating supportive measures for transgender and nonbinary students such as faculty notifications, and more. If you need supportive accommodations, you may contact the Title IX Coordinator directly (titleix@usc.edu or 213-821-8298) without sharing any personal information with me. If you would like to speak with a confidential counselor, Relationship and Sexual Violence Prevention Services (RSVP) provides 24/7 confidential support for students (213-740-9355 (WELL); press 0 after hours).

USC Culture Journey is an initiative aimed at fostering a more **inclusive, values-based, and integrity-driven culture** across the university. The components of the Culture Journey include: community engagement, core values, strategic cultural goals, ongoing assessment, and leadership commitment. Use the following link to see full details on the Culture Journey: https://culturejourney.usc.edu/

Course Structure

This course is taught in a hybrid modality with most of your effort spent working onsite or remotely with the interning agency or business and some time spent communicating with the instructor in-person or at a distance via Zoom or email.

Workload: This is either a 2- or 4-unit, one semester undergraduate course. Students should expect to dedicate 5-8 hours per week (if they chose 2 units) or 10-15 hours per week (if they chose 4 units) to this course.

Course Content Distribution and Synchronous Session Recording Policies

USC has policies that prohibit recording and distribution of any synchronous and asynchronous course content outside of the learning environment.

Recording a university class without the express permission of the instructor and announcement to the class, or unless conducted pursuant to an Office of Accessibility Services (OSAS) accommodation. Recording can inhibit free discussion in the future, and thus infringe on the academic freedom of other students as well as the instructor (Living Our Unifying Values; The USC Student Handbook, page 13).

Distribution or use of notes, recordings, exams, or other intellectual property, based on university classes or lectures without the express permission of the instructor for purposes other than individual or group study is prohibited. This includes but is not limited to providing materials for distribution by services publishing course materials. This restriction on unauthorized use also applies to all information, which has been distributed to students or in any way been displayed for use in relationship to the class, whether obtained in class, via email, on the internet, or via any other media (Living Our Unifying Values; The USC Student Handbook, page 13).

Required Readings and Supplementary Materials

None required. Readings and materials may be recommended by the faculty supervisor.

Description and Assessment of Assignments

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The student and supervising professor must agree upon the format, schedule, and content for the bi-weekly reports and the final paper/report, as outlined in the internship form.

By the Add/Drop deadline of the relevant semester, the student must obtain the signature of the supervising professor and internship company representative on the internship form indicating approval of the proposed internship.

The student is expected to fulfill the terms of the internship at the location of the non-profit organization, private company, or public agency.

At the conclusion of the internship, the student is expected to write a letter of thanks to the relevant appropriate company representative(s) to express appreciation for the opportunity to intern. The student must provide a copy of this thank-you letter to the supervising professor to complete one of the designated assignments.

Final Report

The format and requirements of the final report will be determined by the supervising professor, as agreed to by the student.

The recommended minimum length of the report is 5 pages single-spaced, or 10 pages double-spaced, exclusive of a cover sheet, table of contents, charts, figures, or tables.

The final report is due by the date listed on the Brightspace course site, or unless otherwise noted by the supervising professor.

The report must be the student's authorship, without merely replicating the organization's materials. If materials from the organization are relevant, those materials must be properly cited and can be included as appendices.

Avoid agency, company, non-profit, and/or industry jargon; the report should be comprehensible to someone not familiar with the non-profit organization, private company, or public agency at which you are interning. Define any acronyms.

The final report should follow the outline specified below:

Introduction to the project:

- Describe the organization of the internship, e.g., its mission, constituencies, and role in its industry or sector.
- Identify the division or part of the organization with which the internship was conducted.

Description of the project:

- What were the internship project goals? What were the specific activities that the intern undertook and specifically accomplished?
- What problems or challenges were encountered in this internship and how did the intern address or resolve them? Issues or challenges could include technical problems or relationships with co-workers.
- Describe the internship project results.
- Describe the importance of the internship work to the non-profit organization, private company, or public agency – how did the internship work help the organization conduct its business?

Value of internship:

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- What was learned in this internship, focusing especially on what was new or provided exposure beyond what has been covered in a USC course?
- How did this internship add value to your degree experience?
- How do you anticipate translating the experiences from this internship into your career trajectory?

Grading Breakdown

This course is graded credit/no credit (CR/NC). Students must earn a minimum of 71 points in order to receive a grade of credit (CR). Failure to meet the criteria in this syllabus is grounds for receiving a grade of no credit (NC).

Assignments	**No.**	**Points**
Internship contract	1	10
Bi-monthly status reports via email, virtual meeting, or personal meeting with faculty supervisor (a minimum of six over the course of the semester)	6	30
Internship survey	1	10
Final report	1	40
Letter of appreciation	1	10
TOTAL	**10**	**100**

Assignment Submission Policy

Assignments will be submitted for grading via Brightspace using the due dates specified in the Course Schedule below.

Course Schedule: A Weekly Breakdown

	Topics/Daily Activities	**Deliverables/Due Dates**
Week 1	Defined by internship	Internship contract signed by the relevant parties, due 11:59 p.m. on Friday, 1/23/26
Week 2	Defined by internship	No deliverables
Week 3	Defined by internship	Bi-weekly report 1, due 11:59 p.m. on Friday, 2/6/26
Week 4	Defined by internship	No deliverables
Week 5	Defined by internship	Bi-weekly report 2, due 11:59 p.m. on Friday, 2/20/26
Week 6	Defined by internship	No deliverables
Week 7	Defined by internship	Bi-weekly report 3, due 11:59 p.m. on Friday, 3/6/26
Week 8	Defined by internship	No deliverables
Week 9	Defined by internship	Bi-weekly report 4, due 11:59 p.m. on Friday, 3/27/26

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Week 10	Defined by internship	No deliverables
Week 11	Defined by internship	Bi-weekly report 5, due 11:59 p.m. on Friday, 4/10/26
Week 12	Defined by internship	No deliverables
Week 13	Defined by internship	Bi-weekly report 6, due 11:59 p.m. on Friday, 4/24/26
Week 14	Defined by internship	Internship survey, due 11:59 p.m. on Friday, 5/1/26
Week 15	Defined by internship	Final report and letter of appreciation, due 11:59 p.m. on Monday, 5/11/26

Statement on Academic Conduct and Support Systems

Academic Conduct

The University of Southern California is a learning community committed to developing successful scholars and researchers dedicated to the pursuit of knowledge and the dissemination of ideas. Academic misconduct, which includes any act of dishonesty in the production or submission of academic work, compromises the integrity of the person who commits the act and can impugn the perceived integrity of the entire university community. It stands in opposition to the university mission to research, educate, and contribute productively to our community and the world.

All students are expected to submit assignments that represent their own original work, and that have been prepared specifically for the course or section for which they have been submitted. You may not submit work written by others (including AI generated) or "recycle" work prepared for other courses without obtaining written permission from the instructor(s).

Other violations of academic integrity include, but are not limited to, cheating, plagiarism, fabrication (e.g., falsifying data), collusion, knowingly assisting others in acts of academic dishonesty, and any act that gains or is intended to gain an unfair academic advantage.

The impact of academic dishonesty is far-reaching and is considered a serious offense against the university. All incidences of academic misconduct will be reported to the Office of Academic Integrity and could result in outcomes such as failure on the assignment, failure in the course, suspension, or even expulsion from the university.

Students and Disability Accommodations

USC welcomes students with disabilities into the University's educational programs. The Office of Student Accessibility Services (OSAS) is responsible for the determination of appropriate accommodations for students who encounter disability-related barriers. Once a student has completed the OSAS process (registration, initial appointment, and submitted documentation) and accommodations are determined to be reasonable and appropriate, a Letter of Accommodation (LOA) will be available to generate for each course. The LOA must be given to each course instructor by the student and followed up with a discussion. This should be done as early in the semester as possible as accommodations are not retroactive. More information can be found at osas.usc.edu. You may contact OSAS at (213) 740-0776 or via email at osasfrontdesk@usc.edu.

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Support Systems

Counseling and Mental Health - (213) 740-9355 – 24/7 on call
studenthealth.usc.edu/counseling
Free and confidential mental health treatment for students, including short-term psychotherapy, group counseling, stress fitness workshops, and crisis intervention.

988 Suicide and Crisis Lifeline – 988 for both calls and text messages – 24/7 on call
988lifeline.org/talk-to-someone-now
The 988 Suicide and Crisis Lifeline (formerly known as the National Suicide Prevention Lifeline) provides free and confidential emotional support to people in suicidal crisis or emotional distress 24 hours a day, 7 days a week, across the United States. The Lifeline is comprised of a national network of over 200 local crisis centers, combining custom local care and resources with national standards and best practices. The new, shorter phone number makes it easier for people to remember and access mental health crisis services (though the previous 1 (800) 273-8255 number will continue to function indefinitely) and represents a continued commitment to those in crisis

Relationship and Sexual Violence Prevention Services (RSVP) - (213) 740-9355(WELL), press "0" after hours – 24/7 on call
studenthealth.usc.edu/sexual-assault
Free and confidential therapy services, workshops, and training for situations related to gender-based harm.

Office for Equity, Equal Opportunity, and Title IX (EEO-TIX) - (213) 740-5086
eeotix.usc.edu.
Information about how to get help or help someone affected by harassment or discrimination, rights of protected classes, reporting options, and additional resources for students, faculty, staff, visitors, and applicants.

Reporting Incidents of Bias or Harassment - (213) 740-5086 or (213) 821-8298
usc-advocate.symplicity.com/care_report
Avenue to report incidents of bias, hate crimes, and microaggressions to the Office for Equity, Equal Opportunity, and Title for appropriate investigation, supportive measures, and response.

The Office of Student Accessibility Services (OSAS) - (213) 740-0776
osas.usc.edu
OSAS ensures equal access for students with disabilities through providing academic accommodations and auxiliary aids in accordance with federal laws and university policy.

USC Campus Support and Intervention - (213) 821-4710
campussupport.usc.edu
Assists students and families in resolving complex personal, financial, and academic issues adversely affecting their success as a student.

Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion - (213) 740-2101
diversity.usc.edu
Information on events, programs and training, the Provost's Diversity and Inclusion Council, Diversity Liaisons for each academic school, chronology, participation, and various resources for students.

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USC Emergency - UPC: (213) 740-4321, HSC: (323) 442-1000 – 24/7 on call
dps.usc.edu, emergency.usc.edu
Emergency assistance and avenue to report a crime. Latest updates regarding safety, including ways in which instruction will be continued if an officially declared emergency makes travel to campus infeasible.

USC Department of Public Safety - UPC: (213) 740-6000, HSC: (323) 442-120 – 24/7 on call
dps.usc.edu
Non-emergency assistance or information.

Office of the Ombuds - (213) 821-9556 (UPC) / (323-442-0382 (HSC)
ombuds.usc.edu
A safe and confidential place to share your USC-related issues with a University Ombuds who will work with you to explore options or paths to manage your concern.

*Occupational Therapy Faculty Practice - (323) 442-33*40 or otfp@med.usc.edu
chan.usc.edu/otfp
Confidential Lifestyle Redesign services for USC students to support health promoting habits and routines that enhance quality of life and academic performance.

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